

ART & CULTURE



RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY

MODULE - 4

BUDDHISM- TEACHINGS AND PHILOSOPHY

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHY OF BUDDHA

THE FAMOUS “MIDDLE PATH”!

- 1 Buddhism emphasises on following the middle path for attaining salvation, i.e., a path **neither of self-indulgence nor of extreme asceticism or self-penance.**



VIEWS ON GOD

- 2 Buddha did not believe in god as a creator of the universe or an eternal or unchanging soul.
- 3 However, Buddhist texts do not contain explicit denial of existence of god.
- 4 As such, Buddhism is **not considered as atheistic religion in a strict sense.**
- 5 He was a **rationalist** who tried to explain things in **light of reason** and not on basis of blind faith.

Later on, Mahayana sect believed Buddha himself to be an eternal god.

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHY OF BUDDHA

VIEWS ON AHIMSA

- 6 Buddhist teachings also emphasised on Ahimsa or non-violence (although Buddhism was **more moderate when compared to Jainism** in the extent and strictness to which Ahimsa and its edicts were to be implemented or asceticism was to be adopted).
- 7 Even under gravest provocation Buddha did not show least anger or hatred and instead conquered everyone **by his love and compassion**.

VIEWS ON KARMA

- 8 He laid great emphasis on **law of karma**.
- 9 He argued that condition of man in this life depends upon **his own deeds**.

VIEWS ON SOUL

- 10 Buddhism **does not recognise the existence of soul**.

BUDDHISM

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHY OF BUDDHA

BUDDHISM AS A SOCIAL REVOLUTION

11 Though he did not make a direct attack on the caste system, he was **against any social distinction**

12 People were taken into the Buddhist order without any consideration of caste.

13 Women were also admitted to the **sangha** and thus brought on par with men.

14 His religion was identical with **morality** and it **emphasized purity** of thought, word and deed.

15 In comparison with Brahmanism, Buddhism **was liberal and democratic**.

Therefore, Buddhism was more a social than religious revolution.

BUDDHISM

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHY OF BUDDHA

EMPHASIS ON ETHICS



- 16 It emphasised on **righteous action** for attaining salvation or 'Nibbana' (Nirvana) which literally means extinguishing of the ego and desire.
- 17 It taught the **code of practical ethics** and laid down the principle of **social equality**.
- 18 Buddhism preached against **ritualism, idolatry, animal sacrifices, Brahmanism, and caste system**.

BUDDHISM

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHY OF BUDDHA

19 It bases its philosophy on the **Four Noble Truths** and propounds the **Eightfold path** to attain salvation.

FOUR NOBLE TRUTH

World is full of sorrow

Desire is the cause of sorrow

Triumph over desires leads to prevention of sorrow

Man can avoid Dukkha by avoiding extremes of life and following Eight-fold Paths

EIGHT FOLD PATH OR ASTANGIKA MARGA

- Right Observation
- Right Determination
- Right Action
- Right Speech
- Right Livelihood
- Right Exercise
- Right Memory
- Right Meditation

BUDDHISM

BUDDHIST SCRIPTURES

TRIPITAKAS

The Buddhist philosophy is contained in several important Buddhist scriptures, the most important of which are the Tripitakas. It literally means the three baskets of knowledge and teachings.

VINAYA PITAKA

It contains the details of life of lord Buddha and rules and regulations for functioning of the Sangha.

SUTTA PITAKA

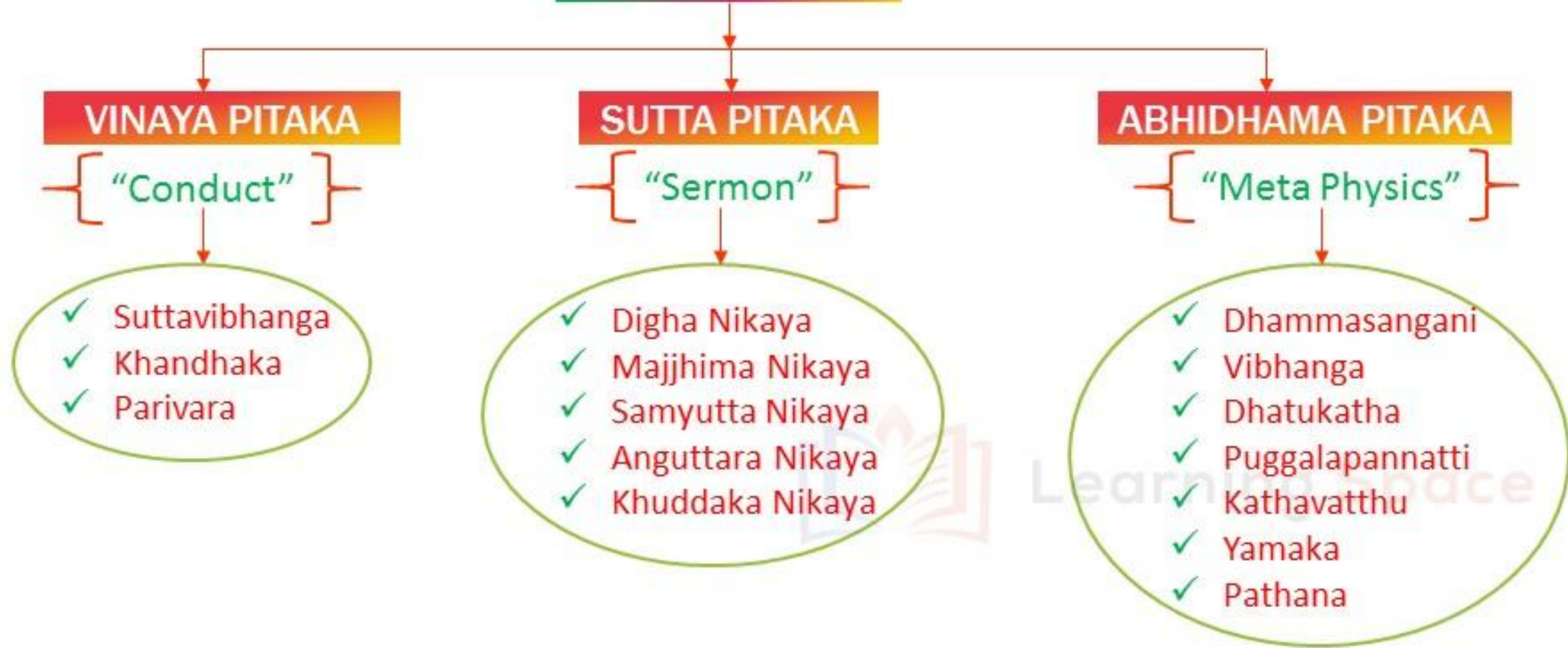
This contains Buddha's sermons on matters of doctrine and ethics.

ABHIDHAMA PITAKA

The metaphysical concepts and philosophy of Buddhism are contained in this Pitaka

BUDDHISM

TRIPITAKAS



The largest and most important of the "3 Baskets" is the Sutta Pitaka which is divided into "5 groups" (Nikaya)

OTHER IMPORTANT BUDDHIST SCRIPTURES

Jatakas	Contain tales of previous births of Buddha in poetry form	
Milind Panha	“Questions of Menander” contains dialogue of the Greco-Bactrian king and Buddhist monk Nagasena	
Dipavamsa	Known as “Chronicle of the Island”	Oldest historical record of Sri Lanka; Pali Literature
Mahavamsa	Known as “Great Chronicle”	Written in Pali literature.
Mahavastu	Written in Sanskrit, Pali and Prakrit	Accounts of earlier lives of Buddha
Buddha Charita	Sanskrit work by Ashavaghosa	
Lalitavistara	Sanskrit text deals with the life story of Buddha	
Divyavadana	Sanskrit text deals with the life story of Buddha	This text basically correlates past lives virtuous deeds to subsequent lives events.
Udana	Pali text	Contains the famous story of “Blind men and Elephant”
Bodhi Vamsa	Mixed Sanskrit-Pali text	Describes about the Buddhist Councils, arrival of branch of Bodhi tree in Sri Lanka and the spread of Buddhism

BUDDHISM

IMPORTANT BODHISATTVAS

IMPORTANT 8 BODHISATTVAS FROM EXAMINATION PERSPECTIVE

- Avalokiteśvara
- Manjusri
- Vajrapani
- Samantabhadra
- Ksitigarbha
- Maitreya
- Sadāparibhūta
- Akasagarbha

1

Boddhisattva means one who has the wish to attain Buddhahood not only for his benefit but for the benefits of all the beings

2

A Boddhisattva is bound to attain enlightenment and refers to all who are destined to become the Buddha in this life or in another life.



IMPORTANT BODHISATTVAS

AVALOKITEŚVARA



- 1 Avalokitesvara literally means “The Lord who Looks Down”.
- 2 He is also called Padmapani meaning the “Lotus-Bearer”.
- 3 His special attribute is compassion towards all living beings of the world.
- 4 A cave wall painting of Avalokiteśvara is present in Ajanta Caves as Padmapani.

IMPORTANT BODHISATTVAS

MANJUSRI



- 1 Manjusri is a manifestation of great wisdom and meditation.
- 2 Manjusri is depicted as a male bodhisattva wielding a flaming sword in his right hand, representing the realization of transcendental wisdom which cuts down ignorance and duality.
- 3 In some statues, he is portrayed with a sword in one hand and the book in the other hand, which describes the cardinal virtues to be followed by the worshipers of Buddha.

BUDDHISM

IMPORTANT BODHISATTVAS

VAJRAPANI



- 1 He is the protector and guide of the Buddha.
- 2 He symbolizes Buddha's power.
- 3 Vajrapani, a sterner Bodhsattva, is the foe of sin and evil, and like the god Indra bears a thunderbolt in his hand.

IMPORTANT BODHISATTVAS

MAITREYA



- 1 The gentle Maitreya is worshipped as a Bodhisattva and he is regarded as future Buddha.
- 2 He is also referred to as Ajita Bodhisattva.
- 3 The prophecy of the arrival of Maitreya refers to a time in the future when the dharma will have been forgotten by most on the terrestrial world.
- 4 We note here that popular Budai or laughing Buddha is claimed to be an incarnation of Maitreya.

BUDDHISM

IMPORTANT BODHISATTVAS



SAMANTABHADRA

SADAPARIBHUTA

He **persevered** in the face of persecution for the sake of the correct teachings of Buddha, and finally attained Buddhahood.

SAMANTABHADRA

Samantabhadra means Universal Worthy and he is associated with **meditation**.

BUDDHISM

IMPORTANT BODHISATTVAS



KSITIGARBHA

- 1 The name literally means “**earth womb**”
- 2 Kṣitigarbha is known for his vow to take responsibility for the instruction of all beings, between the death of Gautama Buddha and the rise of Maitreya, as well as his **vow not to achieve Buddhahood until all hells are emptied.**

BUDDHISM



Manjusri

Wisdom

3 Protection
Deities around
Buddha

Vajrapani

Power

Avalokitesvara

Compassion



BUDDHISM

SECTS IN BUDDHISM

Over a period of time Buddhism divided into several sects, depending on their belief and practice.



1 HINAYANA:

- Literally meaning the **smaller vehicle**, Hinayana emerged as a separate form of Buddhism after the fourth Buddhist Council.
- This was the **orthodox sect** that emphasized on **individual salvation**.
- It follows the **original teachings of Buddha**.
- In this sect, unlike in the Mahayana Sect, Buddha was **not considered as a god**.
- Does not believe in **idol worship**.
- **Thervada** is a Hinayana sect.
- In Hinayana Sect, Buddha and events of his life were represented **symbolically**.
- **Pali** language was used predominantly.

BUDDHISM

SECTS IN BUDDHISM



2

MAHAYANA:

- Literally meaning the **larger vehicle**.
- Believed in **universal salvation** rather than merely the salvation of individuals.
- Mahayana Sect also accepted making of **statues** of Buddha in **Human form** and believed Buddha to be an **eternal god**.
- **Idol worship** was practiced.
- They also followed the **concept of Bodhisattvas** such as Avlokiteshwara, Vajrapani, Kshitigarbha.
- These were venerated souls who had attained personal salvation but took birth on this earth to enable the salvation of other souls.
- **Sanskrit** was their predominant language.
- This sect was propagated by **emperor Kanishka** and later spread far and wide.

BUDDHISM

SECTS IN BUDDHISM

3 THERAVADA:

- This literally means the “**Doctrine of Elders**”.
- Like Hinayana, it emphasized on attaining of **individual “Nirvana”** through mental discipline, appropriate knowledge and right conduct.

4 VAJRAYANA:

- A new form of Buddhism emerged in Bengal and Bihar during the Pala rule under the **influence of tantric sects of Hinduism**.
- This sect worships Buddha, Bodhisattvas and female divinities like Tara.

Buddhism also has regional variations such as Lamaism of Tibet, Sri Lankan Buddhism, Thai Buddhism and Japanese Buddhism.

CONTENTS OF BUDDHISM LECTURES

- ✓ Buddhism- An Introduction
- ✓ Buddhism- A Brief History
- ✓ Spread of Buddhism- Buddhist Councils
- ✓ Teachings & Philosophy of Buddha
- ✓ Buddhist Scriptures
- ✓ Important Bodhisattvas
- ✓ Sects in Buddhism
- ✓ Event & Symbols in Buddhism
- ✓ Places associated with the life of Buddha
- ✓ Mudras of Buddha
- ✓ Causes for the decline

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